

Challenges ahead, but hope intact

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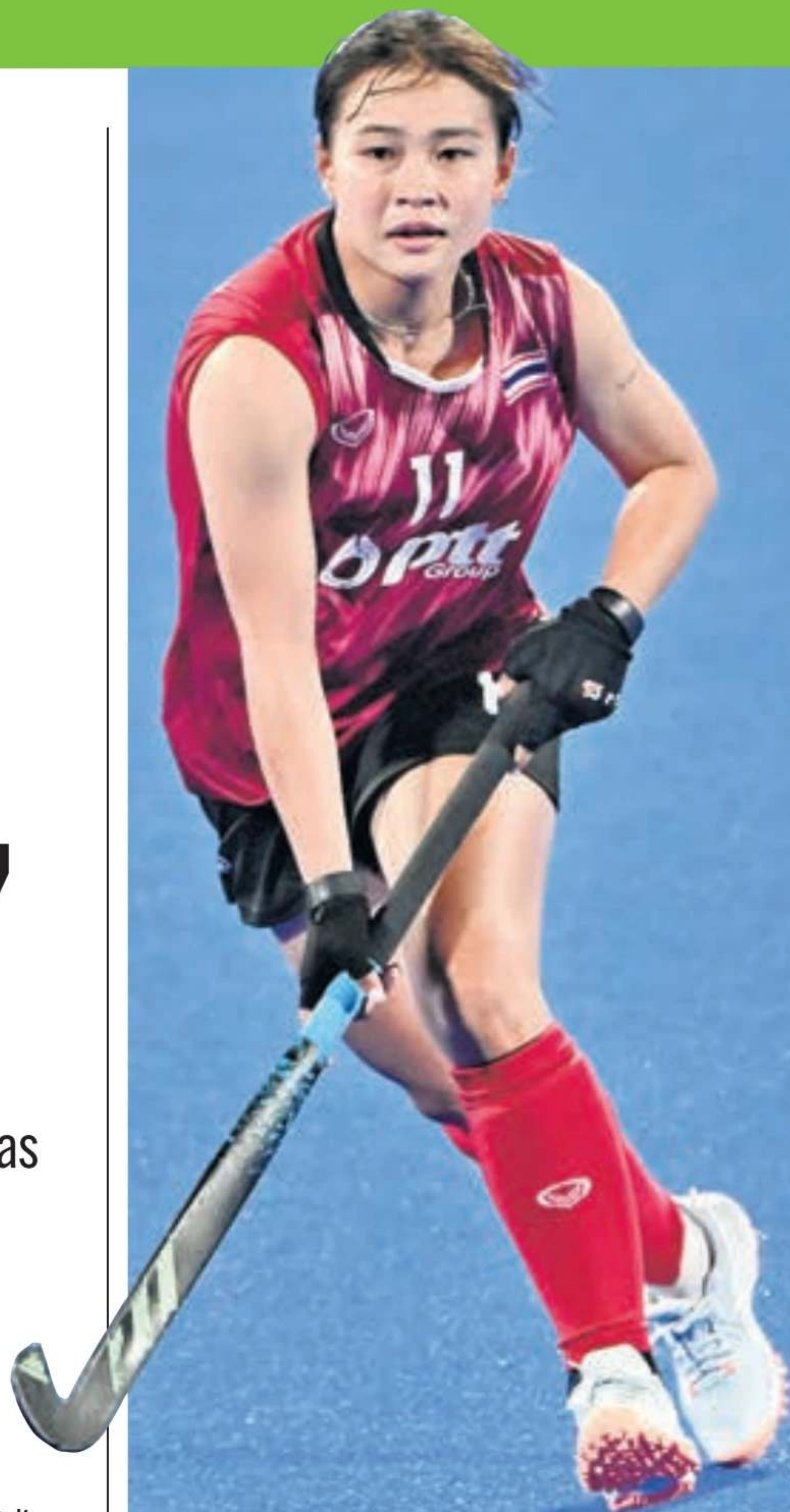
The Women's Hockey India League (HIL-W) would be hopeful that the bumpy ride from the garage to the start line fades into a distant memory before lights-out at the Marang Gomke Jaipal Singh Munda Astro Turf Stadium in Ranchi on January 12.

A reduced number of teams, a lack of adequate cash, and the ever-dwindling count of foreign players may have dealt quite the damage, but Hockey India has not only stayed brave in its wake but also remained committed to the task at hand.

This is the first time an exclusive league for women has found a place in the HIL framework. And frankly, it's been a long time coming. When the high of an unprecedented fourth-place finish at Tokyo 2020 melted into the harrowing lows of non-selection for the Paris Olympics, the sense of disappointment was palpable. **It was evident that although India had a truckload of talent, someone or something needed to switch gears and steer the vehicle in the right direction.**

And maybe, the introduction of HIL-W answers that call by providing a crucial platform for female athletes. What it has surely done already is it has paved the way for a more inclusive future of Indian hockey, with the league running simultaneously alongside the reinstituted men's tournament in Rourkela.

"A few years after I started playing hockey, the men's



HIL started. And that brought about a revolution in the men's game. We saw first-hand how the style of play and mentality of the boys changed post its introduction. Added to that, a lot of players got the chance to showcase their skills. I am expecting the same to happen to us now that we have got a stage to perform on. We will be